LX

DEMOCRACY IN EAST AND WEST

I was surprised to find in Alipore that no daily paper would be allowed to me after my conviction. As an under-trial prisoner I received the daily *Statesman*, of Calcutta, but this was stopped the day after my trial was over. In the U.P., ever since 1932, a daily (chosen by the Government) was permitted to A Class or first division prisoners. So also in most other provinces, and I was fully under the impression that the same rule was applicable in Bengal. Instead of the daily, however, I was supplied with the weekly *Statesman*. This was evidently meant for retired English officials or business men who had gone back to England, and it contained a summary of Indian news likely to interest them. No foreign news at all was given and I missed it very much, as I used to follow it closely. Fortunately I was allowed to have the *Manchester Guardian Weekly*, and this kept me in touch with Europe and international affairs.

My arrest and trial in February coincided with upheavals and bitter conflicts in Europe. There was the ferment in France resulting in Fascist riots and the formation of a 'National' Government. And, far worse, in Austria Chancellor Dolfuss was shooting down workers and putting an end to the great edifice of social democracy there. The news of the Austrian bloodshed depressed me greatly. What an awful and bloody place this world was and how barbarous was man when he wanted to protect his vested interests! All over Europe and America Fascism seemed to be advancing. When Hitler came into power in Germany I had imagined that his régime could not possibly last long, as he was offering no solution of Germany's economic troubles. So also, as Fascism spread elsewhere, I consoled myself that it represented the last ditch of reaction. After it must come the breaking of the shackles. But I began to wonder if my wish was not father to my thought. Was it so obvious that this Fascist wave would retire so easily or so quickly? And even if conditions became intolerable for the Fascist dictatorships, would they not rather hurl their countries into devastating war rather than give in? What would be the result of such a conflict?

Meanwhile, Fascism of various kinds and shapes spread. Spain, that new 'Republic of Honest Men'—*los hombres*